



FROM BAD M TO GOOD M:
A shrill Banerjee (below) drove Tata out but Modi was quick to embrace him

Bushan Steel's Rs 8,800-crore plan and Vedanta Group's Rs 20,000 crore for setting up aluminium manufacturing capacities in Burdwan district. In the oil sector are capex plan worth Rs 20,000 crore with Cals Refineries' 20 million tonne per annum capacity refinery project in Haldia and Nayachar district for the next five years and Larsen & Turbo has a plan to set up new ship building projects worth Rs 2,500 crore for the next two years. The state Industry Minister Nirupam Sen was among the saddest men in Kolkata last weekend. "For their political gains, the main Opposition party has played a destructive role. I don't know how much they have gained, but it certainly is a big loss for the people of West Bengal," he said. And though thousands of crores of investment has been pledged, what now matters is how they are seen in the light of the Tata pullout. "If they feel that the land allotted to them may be contested, there could be rethinking," says Mitra.

But there is a significant section for whom industrial prospects in Bengal continue to hold promises. The Nano pullout notwithstanding, there are


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many things working for this fertile state, according to Sajjan Jindal, Associated Chambers of Commerce and Industry of India (ASSOCHAM) president and steel tycoon, who has a Rs 35,000-crore steel plant planned for Bengal. The manufacturing sector, which constitutes around 54 per cent of the industrial product, has been growing at nine per cent. "The state stands

at seventh position among all states in terms of disbursement of scheduled commercial credit which in 2006-07 was Rs 77,391 crore and has grown at the rate of 21 per cent and 23 per cent in fiscal '07 and fiscal '06," says Jindal.

All is not lost though. A day after the Tata pullout, the ASSOCHAM lent its support to the chief minister. "This is just unfortunate. But it doesn't mean that the Government of West Bengal has lost the confidence of India Inc or overseas investors," its secretary D.S. Rawat wrote in a letter to Bhattacharya.

How much will all this alter the state's political equations? The earlier hints are likely by November end, when the Howrah Municipal Corporation elections are due. After the Nandigram fiasco, the CPI(M) had seen major setbacks in Singur and Nandigram during the panchayat elections in May. A more accurate picture will emerge next year when the Lok Sabha elections take place. Banerjee claims her shrill protests were aimed at protecting the rights of the farmers. She will soon get to know if the ones she had been fighting for still keep their faith in her. ■